THE DAILY BRIEF

JULY 26, 2026

AI & TECH

Artificial intelligence, models, and the industry built around them

Monday.com Becomes the 21st Big Tech Company This Year to Blame AI for Mass Layoffs. The workforce management platform told employees this week that AI-driven efficiency gains were directly responsible for the decision to cut staff. It is now the 21st major technology company in 2026 to publicly cite artificial intelligence as the primary driver of significant layoffs — a trend that started with Klarna's CEO announcing the company would become "AI-first" and has since spread to giants including Google, Microsoft, Salesforce, and SAP. Economists are divided: some argue this is creative destruction in real time, while others point to a 6.2% drop in tech job postings since January as evidence that the displacement is structural rather than cyclical. (TechCrunch)

OpenAI's New AI Keypad Turns Code Writing Into Something Closer to Music Production. OpenAI this week shipped what it is calling an AI keypad — a physical input device that maps natural language prompts to code generation in a workflow that feels closer to a synthesizer than an IDE. Early users describe it as "slightly mystifying to everyone except the coders who love it." The device connects to OpenAI's API and runs model inference locally for simple completions, routing more complex requests to the cloud. At $199, it sits in an awkward middle ground between a productivity tool and a toy — but OpenAI's developer ecosystem has a history of making awkward-sounding products stick. (TechCrunch)

One Fallen Power Line Nearly Shut Down America's AI Infrastructure — Here's the Fix Being Proposed. A single downed transmission line in Northern Virginia last month triggered a near-miss at one of the world's largest AI data center campuses, exposing just how brittle the power grid supporting America's AI boom has become. Data centers in the region — which handle roughly 70% of all U.S. AI inference traffic — have been expanding far faster than utility companies can upgrade transformers and distribution lines. The proposed solution involves a mix of on-site nuclear micro-reactors, direct power purchase agreements with independent generators, and grid-edge battery systems that can ride out short disruptions without skipping a beat. The irony is not lost on anyone: AI companies building data centers to save the climate are running headfirst into a grid problem partly caused by their own energy appetite. (TechCrunch)

Librarians Are Running Viral "Avoiding AI" Workshops for People Who Want Nothing to Do With Big Tech. Across public libraries in Chicago, Portland, Austin, and Boston, free workshops teaching people how to minimize their AI footprint have drawn standing-room-only crowds. Topics range from opting out of algorithmic recommendations and deleting AI assistants to understanding which apps silently embed AI features without asking. The movement is largely generational — median age of attendees is 47 — but organizers say younger participants are showing up too, specifically worried about AI résumé screening and automated housing decisions. It is a curious cultural signal: while companies race to embed AI into every surface, a meaningful cohort of Americans is actively trying to opt out. (TechCrunch)

MARKETS & FINANCE

Stock markets, crypto, prediction markets, and economic signals

Robinhood Is in Talks to Add Crypto.com Prediction Markets, Turning the Kalshi Rivalry Into a Full-Blown War. Robinhood is negotiating a deal that would let its customers trade yes-or-no contracts through Crypto.com's derivatives business, according to a Wall Street Journal report published Saturday. The move would put Robinhood — long known for stock trading and, more recently, crypto — directly into the prediction market business currently dominated by Kalshi, which has seen explosive volume growth since the 2024 election cycle. Kalshi has been on a regulatory offensive, successfully challenging the CFTC's attempt to restrict event contracts and expanding into markets on everything from Fed rate decisions to Grammy winners. If Robinhood Crypto.com lands, expect volume in binary contracts to surge again — Robinhood's user base dwarfs both platforms combined. No deal has been signed. (WSJ via The Block)

Bitcoin ETF Trading Volume Just Hit Its Lowest Level Since October 2024. Weekly trading volume on U.S. bitcoin exchange-traded funds fell to its lowest reading in 21 months last week, a stark contrast to the record inflows seen in the first quarter. Ether funds, meanwhile, have been drawing in nearly as much capital as bitcoin ETFs over the past three weeks despite holding roughly one-eighth as much in net assets — a ratio that suggests traders are rotating into Ethereum on expectations of broader altcoin adoption. The volume drop is being read two ways: either bitcoin is entering a quiet accumulation phase, or retail interest in crypto ETFs is fading after the post-election euphoria wore off. The truth is probably both, simultaneously, which is roughly what you would expect from a market that 80 million Americans now have some exposure to through their retirement accounts. (The Block)

EU Bars HTX and Seven Other Crypto Platforms From Operating in Europe Starting August 23. European regulators added HTX, EXMO, Rapira, BitPapa, Aifory Pro, WhiteBird, NoOnecrypto, and Exnode to the Russia sanctions list this week, meaning all transactions with those platforms must cease by August 23 or face penalties under the EU's sweeping crypto-asset framework. The action is the latest in a series of enforcement moves targeting platforms that Brussels believes are being used to circumvent sanctions on Russian entities. HTX, formerly known as Huobi, is one of the largest crypto exchanges by volume and has long been a destination for users in Asia and emerging markets. The designation effectively cuts off European users and, more significantly, raises questions about whether U.S. banking partners will now distance themselves from the platform to avoid secondary sanctions exposure. (The Block)

BRIEFLY

‹ **Palantir and Anduril joined the U.S. State Department's newly launched Freedom Tech Excellence Program** alongside the Bitcoin Policy Institute, signaling a convergence between defense technology firms and cryptocurrency policy advocacy inside the government. (The Block)

‹ **Cardano co-founder Charles Hoskinson argued this week that Bitcoin risks losing its top ranking** if it fails to upgrade its governance system to handle quantum computing threats — a criticism that is technically valid but has been leveled at every proof-of-stake chain for six years without incident. (The Block)

‹ **SpaceX will attempt to catch its Starship booster back at the launch tower on its next flight**, the company confirmed after a successful 13th integrated flight test that saw both the booster and spacecraft land intact. It is a spectacle that would have seemed impossible a decade ago and is now becoming routine. (Ars Technica)

THE TAKEAWAY

The defining tension of this Sunday is not any single story — it is the gap between two simultaneous realities. In one corner, OpenAI keeps shipping hardware, Monday.com keeps cutting people, and data centers keep eating power lines. The AI industry is moving at a pace that makes regulation and infrastructure planning look glacial by comparison. In the other corner, a meaningful portion of the public is attending library workshops on how to participate in that economy as little as possible. These are not contradictions — they are the market finding its equilibrium, the same way early internet adoption and anti-surveillance tooling coexisted for 15 years before anyone agreed on what privacy meant. The prediction market boom, meanwhile, is quietly becoming the most interesting financial story of 2026: Robinhood, Kalshi, and Crypto.com are fighting over a market that did not exist three years ago and is already large enough to move headlines. That is where the smart money is paying attention right now.

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